

Microsoft releases open source Office 365 SDK for Android

In a clear attempt to capitalise on the success of the Android platform and draw more users to Microsoft products, Microsoft has now released an open source SDK for Office 365. Microsoft Open Technologies, the company's open source subsidiary, has released the SDK for the Android platform under the Apache License, version 2.0.

It must be noted that Microsoft has had the Office Mobile for Microsoft 365 app in the Play Store for some time now. However, making the SDK open will help Android developers a great deal in accessing Office 365 data from their apps. In short, Office 365 is now more relevant to the vast Android user base. This SDK will make it possible to use data stored in Microsoft Office 365 from your Android Apps. For instance, Kingsoft Office and Documents To Go can now access your Office 365 data on your Android device.

The SDK will provide access to:

- Microsoft Exchange Mail
- Microsoft Exchange Contacts
- Microsoft Exchange Calendar
- Microsoft SharePoint Lists
- Microsoft SharePoint Files

Further, it will be compatible with Android APIs 15 through 18 (4.0.3, 4.1.2, 4.2.2 and 4.3). KitKat users will have to wait a little longer to get their hands on the SDK.

Indian users of FB Messenger can now make free VoIP calls from Android devices

Facebook's Messenger 'VOIPFacebook' has made its way into Indian Android devices, as the company has introduced the voice-calling feature for FB Messenger users. Facebook did not make an official announcement in the context, but as per various reports, the feature was rolled out some time in the last week.

This feature was primarily introduced on Android-based devices in March 2013, but was not available in India until now. The voice-calling feature for the Facebook Messenger enables users to call their Facebook contacts for free via a 3G or Wi-Fi network.

If you use Messenger, you can activate this feature on your smart device (smartphone or tablet) by first opening a message thread with a friend. Then tap the Android menu button and select *Free Call*. However, if you fail to see this option, the feature may not be operational at the moment on your device.



Baxter Robot teaches students at the University of California

We have seen robots employed in manufacturing industries, in the medical field and even in the entertainment sector. Now they have branched out into a new career path at the University of California, Berkeley. A robot named Baxter now teaches students. 'He' has been invented by Rodney Brooks, founder of the start-up Rethink Robotics and one of the world's most celebrated roboticists.

Baxter teaches a class of about 30 students about the principles of using and coding for robotics, along with a professor. He runs on the open source Robot Operating System (ROS) which is embedded in his chest. With a friendly face and an animated screen programmed with a smile, Baxter has sensors in his head which help him to sense people nearby and adapt into an environment. At present, students use Python and other coding languages to control Baxter's various sensors.

Safety issues and the lack of a universal operating system were the two road blocks that earlier prevented robots from teaching. That said, Baxter is known to be one of the safest robots on earth. Also, he is powered by a universal operating system, based on which developers can build apps that can run across a variety of machines, as the OS supports app development. Students have even developed programs that enable Baxter to 'clean up' a table. Using its camera and other sensors, Baxter was able to identify the objects and move them back to their original resting spots.

Compared to other robots, Baxter is cost effective too. While other robots cost around US\$ 250,000, Baxter is available for US\$ 22,000. Rethink Robotics had built an industrial robot with the same name in 2012. Industry experts believe that experiments like Baxter will revolutionise the teaching domain in the coming years.